Shah Shuja, Macnaghten, even his old grouse-shooting companion ‘Elphy Bey’, were to be left to sort out the mess on their own. No help would be coming from Calcutta.

Snow fell heavily in Kabul during the second week of December, billowing down from the Hindu Kush, instantly turning the dusty grey hills around the city a dazzling white, settling thickly on the parapets of the cantonment and freezing the Kabul River. ‘The snow did not trouble the Sardars and ghazis who were in their element,’ wrote Mirza ‘Ata, ‘but the army from India was unused to snow and many died. Many others became incapable of fighting because of the intense cold.’[109]

Yet for Macnaghten the snow was the least of his worries. He had, as agreed, handed over the two remaining fortresses overlooking the cantonment as well as the large down-payments demanded by the sardars, including 20,000 rupees to Akbar Khan, but still the promised food and fodder had only arrived in dribs and drabs and the army and their pack animals remained on the verge of starvation.[110] Nor was there any sign of the promised carts and baggage animals the English would need to transport their goods back to India. As a result, the 14 December deadline for the departure of the army passed without the slightest movement. Meanwhile, any remaining defiance within the cantonment had ebbed into a cowed anxiety and fear. ‘So great was the want of common sense’, wrote Mackenzie,

> that hundreds of the enemy, armed to the teeth, were allowed to insinuate themselves into the cantonments and to walk about spying everything. A Ghilzai drew his sword on Lt Sturt within a few yards of a loaded 6-pounder, because that officer endeavoured to keep back the man’s insolent comrades. So strictly were the sentries forbidden to fire, that our camp followers and friendly Afghans were often robbed and even killed a dozen yards from our walls, and the mess sheep of the 5th Cavalry were captured within 150 yards of the ramparts, under the eyes of the whole garrison.[111]

Realising the desperate state the British were in, Akbar Khan now increased his demands. More cannon were to be surrendered. Yet more hostages were demanded. Seeing the bottomless pit that they were falling into, Macnaghten again raised with his commanders the idea of retreating to the Bala Hisar or even reopening hostilities with the Afghans now that their guard was down, ‘to march out at once in order of battle [in Lawrence’s